

# Best of St. Louis

Your Insider Guide to the Gateway City

*Curated by locals. No filler. No tourist clichés.*

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## What's inside:

- The Neighborhoods — Soulard, Central West End, Maplewood, Tower Grove & more
- Dining & Drinking — Clayton's restaurant renaissance, CWE stalwarts, South Grand
- Arts & Culture — SLAM, the Fox, the Muny, First Friday galleries
- Seasonal Calendar — What to do every month of the year
- Weekend Itinerary — A full Saturday from farmers market to live music

*This guide is published by STL Gateway Living — a newsletter for people who live here, written with honest local perspective. Subscribe at [stlgatewayliving.com](http://stlgatewayliving.com).*

## SECTION 1

# The Neighborhoods

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St. Louis is a city of distinct neighborhoods, each with its own character, history, and unwritten rules. Here's how the locals read them.

## Soulard

Soulard is the oldest neighborhood in the city and carries itself accordingly — French street names, brick row houses from the 1880s, and a Saturday farmers market that has been running continuously since 1779. The market anchors the south end on Carroll Street: produce vendors who've had the same stall for 30 years, a butcher counter, tamale stands. Hammerstone's on Geyer Avenue is the dive bar with live blues most weekends — no frills, cheap beer, and the music is the point. Morgan Street Brewery has been in the neighborhood for decades and pours decent lagers without the craft-beer theater. The housing stock is dense and affordable relative to the west side — young couples and long-time residents coexist on the same blocks.

**Best for: History, live music, and the best farmers market in the metro.**

## Central West End

Central West End is where the city's doctors, architects, and gallery owners live — not because they can't afford Ladue, but because they don't want to. The neighborhood runs along Euclid Avenue and Maryland Plaza, a stretch of sidewalk cafes and independent boutiques that feels genuinely walkable. Left Bank Books on Euclid is the kind of neighborhood bookstore where the staff has opinions and isn't shy about them. Taste on Euclid does modern American with a long wine list; Vito's Sicilian Pizzeria is the counter-argument to any claim that good pizza requires a flight to New York. The neighborhood borders Forest Park — residents treat it as their backyard.

**Best for: Urban professionals who want walkability, bookshops, and Forest Park access.**

## Maplewood

Maplewood is technically its own municipality but functionally an extension of the city's inner-ring neighborhoods. Manchester Road is the main commercial strip and has quietly become one of the better dining streets in the metro. Robust Espresso anchors the morning crowd; the line out the door on weekends is a reliable sign that the coffee is serious. Start Bar on Manchester is built around arcade games and pinball machines — it's exactly what it sounds like and it works. Lona's Lil Eats does Vietnamese-influenced small plates that draw people from across the county. The neighborhood is flat and bikeable, with the Centennial Greenway trail used for actual transportation.

**Best for: Younger households who want lower rents without sacrificing character or walkability.**

## Tower Grove

Tower Grove South and Tower Grove East share Tower Grove Park — 289 acres of Victorian-era design with pavilions, fountains, and picnic groves. Grand Avenue between Arsenal and Gravois is the commercial corridor:

dense, walkable, and more diverse in residents and restaurants than almost anywhere else in the metro. Pho Grand has been on South Grand for decades and remains the reference point for Vietnamese food in the city. Mangia Italiano is the neighborhood trattoria that locals book a week out on Friday nights. The Saturday morning farmers market in Tower Grove Park (May–October) draws residents who live close enough to walk with a tote bag.

**Best for: Families and long-term residents who value front-porch culture and neighborhood diversity.**

## Clayton

Premier residential and business district — tree-lined streets, historic architecture mixed with modern developments. Shaw Park hosts outdoor concerts and a farmers market (Sundays May–October). Clayton Road features high-end retail, upscale restaurants, and professional services in a genuinely walkable downtown. Clayton High School is ranked among the top schools in Missouri. The neighborhood has attracted a culinary renaissance: 'Garden Table' (farm-to-table), 'Clayton Cellars' (wine bar with small plates), and upscale American bistros are drawing diners from across the metro.

**Best for: Affluent families who want excellent schools, walkable retail, and a polished neighborhood feel.**

## SECTION 2

# Dining & Drinking

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*St. Louis is becoming a food destination. Here's where the locals actually eat.*

## Clayton & Central West End

The culinary center of gravity. Clayton averaging \$45–\$65 per entree at the new upscale openings; Central West End at \$35–\$55 with more chef-driven concepts. Farm-to-table sourcing is the baseline, not a marketing claim. Outdoor seating is a priority at every new opening.

**Standouts:** Garden Table, Clayton Cellars, Taste (CWE)

## South Grand / Tower Grove

South Grand is the city's most diverse dining corridor. Pho Grand is the decades-long Vietnamese reference point. Mangia Italiano books out a week ahead on weekends. The stretch between Arsenal and Gravois has Thai, Ethiopian, and Mexican restaurants within a few blocks — the kind of density that most mid-size cities don't achieve.

**Price range:** \$15–\$40 per person

## Soulard & Maplewood

Soulard's tavern culture goes back to the neighborhood's working-class roots. Hammerstone's is live blues and cheap beer; Morgan Street Brewery is the neighborhood lager spot without pretension. Maplewood's Lona's Lil Eats draws a county-wide crowd for Vietnamese-influenced small plates; Robust Espresso is among the city's strongest morning anchors.

**Price range:** \$12–\$35 per person

## SECTION 3

# Arts & Culture

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*The St. Louis Art Museum is free. The Zoo is free. Forest Park is free. Most cities would charge for all of it.*

## St. Louis Art Museum (SLAM)

One of the best art museums in the country, housed in a 1904 Beaux-Arts building in Forest Park. Free general admission drives record attendance. Contemporary galleries in Cherokee Street and Grand Center are gaining national recognition. First Friday art walks are becoming major social events citywide.

## The Fox Theatre

One of the most ornate movie palaces in the country, now presenting Broadway tours, concerts, and diverse programming. The Siamese-Byzantine interior — gilded ornament, massive chandeliers — is worth seeing regardless of what's on stage. Tickets range widely; check the calendar before hotel booking.

## The Muny

The Municipal Opera in Forest Park — the largest outdoor musical theater in the country, 11,000 seats, and free seats available at the back of the house on a first-come basis. June through August season. Bring a blanket; the temperature drops after 9pm.

## Missouri Botanical Garden

Cherry blossoms in spring, Shakespeare in the Park (Forest Park) in summer, the Japanese Garden year-round. The Garden is one of the oldest botanical institutions in the United States and remains a neighborhood anchor for CWE and Tower Grove residents who treat it as a weekly destination, not a tourist stop.

## The National Blues Museum

On Broadway in the downtown core. One of the better-curated music history experiences in the country — the exhibition on the St. Louis blues corridor documents the city's underappreciated role in the genre's development. Opens late on select Fridays with live performances.

## SECTION 4

# Seasonal Calendar

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*What to do in St. Louis, broken down by season — because the city changes radically.*

### **Spring (March–May)**

Cherry blossom viewing at Missouri Botanical Garden. Cardinals opening day at Busch Stadium. Outdoor dining season begins in earnest — patio culture resumes. Farmers markets return (Tower Grove Park, Shaw Park, Soulard Market picking up Saturday volume). St. Patrick's Day parade through downtown is the city's largest street event of the year.

### **Summer (June–August)**

Shakespeare in the Park (Forest Park, free). Outdoor movie series. Cardinals baseball peak season. The Muny's season runs June through August — free seats available. Patio dining everywhere. Jazz at the Bistro summer series. Riverfront activities. Steinberg Skating Rink in Forest Park converts to a splash pad.

### **Fall (September–November)**

Oktoberfest celebrations across the metro. Fall foliage tours — the Missouri River bluffs east of the city provide dramatic color. Halloween events in Soulard and CWE. Outdoor festivals before the cold arrives. Apple picking within an hour's drive in the hill country.

### **Winter (December–February)**

Holiday light displays at Missouri Botanical Garden (Garden Glow) and across the metro. Indoor theater season — Fox Theatre and Rep Theatre programming peaks. Museum exhibitions. Ice skating at Steinberg Rink in Forest Park. Mardi Gras in Soulard is the largest celebration outside New Orleans — the neighborhoods fills, 12th Street gets loud, locals know to plan around it.

## SECTION 5

# A Perfect St. Louis Saturday

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### 8:00 AM — Soulard Market or Tower Grove Farmers Market

Soulard runs year-round; Tower Grove Park market runs May–October. Both are legitimate markets — farmers, butchers, prepared food. Get there early.

### 10:00 AM — Forest Park

SLAM (St. Louis Art Museum), the Zoo, and the Missouri History Museum are all free. The park's 1,300 acres include jogging paths, a golf course, and the Steinberg Rink (seasonal). Residents treat this as their backyard — you should too.

### 12:30 PM — Lunch in Central West End

Taste on Euclid for a sit-down lunch with a long wine list. Vito's for pizza if the line at Taste is discouraging. Left Bank Books on Euclid is the post-lunch stop.

### 2:30 PM — Cherokee Street or Grand Center Galleries

First Friday (first Friday of each month) brings the galleries to life — Cherokee Street's contemporary spaces and Grand Center's national-profile venues. On other days, the Fox Theatre lobby is worth walking through even without a ticket.

### 5:00 PM — The Missouri Botanical Garden

Closes at 5pm in winter, 8pm in summer. The Japanese Garden, the Climatron conservatory, and the temperate house are the anchors. Buy the year pass if you're planning to return.

### 7:00 PM — Dinner in Soulard or South Grand

Soulard tavern fare at Molly's. South Grand's Mangia Italiano (book ahead). Pho Grand for Vietnamese if you want the best bowl in the city.

### 9:00 PM — Live Music

Hammerstone's in Soulard for blues. National Blues Museum for scheduled performances. Jazz at the Bistro for a more formal evening.

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**STL Gateway Living publishes a free weekly newsletter with events, restaurant openings, and neighborhood news — every Thursday. Subscribe at [stlgatewayliving.com](https://stlgatewayliving.com).**